

PRACTICAL ADVICE FROM THE BIBLE

BRANDON SNOKE

Donna and I spent a recent weekend in Ouray, Colorado, a charming little mountain town. Our room overlooked a stream that ran non stop. After coming from the hot desert it was refreshing to see endless fresh waters and cool weather. As we lay side by side taking a short rest after some hiking, I listened to the rushing stream and gave God thanks for this precious moment with my most beloved wife. It occurred to me that this stream has always been here, I just needed to come to it.

As we have heard and know, there is a river of life flowing from the throne of God, but I would like to explore one of the sources of this life-giving river. The source is instruction by the Holy Spirit.

Years ago, I ran a particularly awesome crane (Donna named it Towanda) for eight years straight. It was German-made with translated load charts in English and an operator's manual that explained in detail every capability of the crane, and the operation of its very complex computer. I learned just enough to operate the crane safely and then just put my head down and went to work, 60 to 100 hours per week for 8 years.

When I moved to a different job another operator began using Towanda and showed me how the computer will calculate the percentage of your load at the push of a button.

There was much in the computer that would have made my hours less stressful and more enjoyable if I had taken the time to "follow all of the instructions" instead of just getting on with the basics.

God gave us the gift of marriage and He sent that gift with an operator's manual. We can just wing it and get by with the basics or we can apply God's instructions and get the most out of our marriage.

"Submit to one another out of reverence for Christ. Wives, submit yourselves to your own husbands as you do to the Lord. For the husband is the head of the wife as Christ is the head of the church, his body, of which he is the Savior. Now as the church submits to Christ, so also wives should submit to their husbands in everything. Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her to make her holy, cleansing her by the washing with water through the word, and to present her to himself as a radiant church, without stain or wrinkle or any other blemish, but holy and blameless. In this same way, husbands ought to love their wives as their own bodies. He who loves his wife loves himself. After all, no one ever hated his own body, but he feeds and cares for it, just as Christ does the church—for we are members of his body. 'For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and the two

will become one flesh. 'This is a profound mystery—but I am talking about Christ and the church. However, each one of you also must love his wife as he loves himself, and the wife must respect her husband' (Ephesians 5:21-33, NIV).

When we do something as simple as live life in the order God wrote in His operator's manual, it pleases God.

When husbands love their wives, it pleases God. When wives submit to and respect their husbands, it pleases God.

Then there is verse 32, *"This is a profound mystery—but I am talking about Christ and the church"* (Ephesians 5:32, NIV).

I think we all know this, but it is good to ponder it at times. When we exercise the proper order at home and in a marriage, we are practicing the order of the kingdom; the relationship between Christ and His church. What are some of those characteristics?

- **Fidelity, faithfulness:** Honor and serve only one God and Savior.
- **Love, sacrifice:** Christ already showed and has continued to show sacrificial love to his church. We need to practice the same love towards one another and towards Christ
- **Submission:** To one another and to God and Christ. In a home there must be a head, in the church Christ must be the Head.
- **Become one:** There is a time when a man leaves his mother and father and joins with his wife and they become one. They blend almost into one person. I think God recognizes them almost as one person. We must become like Christ, let Him mold us into His likeness, and then God will recognize us as one person, in Christ.

"Husbands, in the same way be considerate as you live with your wives, and treat them with respect as the weaker partner and as heirs with you of the gracious gift of life, so that nothing will hinder your prayers" (1 Peter 3:7, NIV).

God's ways are always worth seeking out and following. Lewis and Clark, the leaders of the Corps of Discovery, set out in 1804 with a party of 45 souls to search out a navigable route across the western United States to the Pacific Ocean. At one stop they sent out a young man alone to hunt game to feed the group. The young man got lost and after searching for him for 3 days the group thought he had died and proceeded up the Missouri River. The young man eventually found his way back to the river bank, but the party was gone. He followed the river bank for 16 days looking for the boat until he was near starvation and sat on the bank hoping a boat would come by. He didn't stop looking. He eventually found the group and helped them make history. This young man was diligently seeking out his salvation, which in his case

was a boat and his group. It was worth giving his last ounce of energy for, and so are the ways of God to the believer.

So what are some of these instructions or ways of God? First of all, I am not laying out anything new, just a few things God has instructed us in, to help us make the most of our lives.

I would like to talk briefly on topics of:

Marriage, Stewardship, Tithing, Work, and Prayer

Marriage

Between one man and one woman. It is a holy union. We have already read Ephesians 5:21-33. God has this particular order for marriage. The husband as a loving head is willing to sacrifice his life for his wife. He loves his wife as if she is his own flesh. The wife honors, respects, and submits to her husband. Some may disagree with this arrangement and some may choose to do it differently. That is every couple's choice, but to make the most of a marriage, we must follow God's instructions and order our home as God intended. Otherwise we are missing out.

Stewardship

"Each of you should use whatever gift you have received to serve others, as faithful stewards of God's grace in its various forms" (1 Peter 4:10, NIV).

"Let a man so account of us, as of the ministers of Christ, and stewards of the mysteries of God. Moreover it is required in stewards, that a man be found faithful" (1 Corinthians 4:1-2, KJV).

God gives us many blessings. This is an abbreviated list of what God has given me, as an example. He has given me: a wife, children, home, job, car, spiritual gifts, health, finances, etc. and I am to take care of each of these things, and be faithful to what God has blessed me with.

I think one of the evils or dangers of this world is the enticement to always be purchasing something more, better, newer, bigger. The world's financial system thrives on people spending their finances on many non essential things. Banks pile up wealth off of credit card fees, especially late fees and high interest rates. We need to be good stewards of our finances. Just because a bank tells you that you can afford a new car or bigger house doesn't mean it is wise to do so. Keep in mind that banks make money on financially enslaving you.

Tithing

Tithing is not an area to cut back on in your budget. We have learned and scripture bears it out, that tithing is entering into a business arrangement with God. It is far better than any stock on Wall Street. It usually doesn't show up on your bank statement so it's also tax free. Tithing works in different ways. Sometimes your refrigerator lasts for 40 years or maybe your car just won't wear out. Your paycheck somehow goes farther, or your employer gives you lots of work or overtime. Many times these things work together with being obedient

in more than one discipline, like being a good steward and working those extra hours that your boss entrusts you with.

“Will a man rob God? Yet ye have robbed me. But ye say, Wherein have we robbed thee? In tithes and offerings. Ye are cursed with a curse: for ye have robbed me, even this whole nation. Bring ye all the tithes into the storehouse, that there may be meat in mine house, and prove me now herewith, saith the LORD of hosts, if I will not open you the windows of heaven, and pour you out a blessing, that there shall not be room enough to receive it. And I will rebuke the devourer for your sakes, and he shall not destroy the fruits of your ground; neither shall your vine cast her fruit before the time in the field, saith the LORD of hosts. And all nations shall call you blessed: for ye shall be a delightsome land, saith the LORD of hosts” (Malachi 3:8-12, KJV).

Work

“Now we command you, brethren, in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, that ye withdraw yourselves from every brother that walketh disorderly, and not after the tradition which he received of us. For yourselves know how ye ought to follow us: for we behaved not ourselves disorderly among you; neither did we eat any man’s bread for nought; but wrought with labour and travail night and day, that we might not be chargeable to any of you: not because we have not power, but to make ourselves an ensample unto you to follow us. For even when we were with you, this we commanded you, that if any would not work, neither should he eat. For we hear that there are some which walk among you disorderly, working not at all, but are busybodies. Now them that are such we command and exhort by our Lord Jesus Christ, that with quietness they work, and eat their own bread” (2 Thessalonians 3:6-12, KJV).

“Whatever you do, work at it with all your heart, as working for the Lord, not for human masters” (Colossians 3:23, NIV).

Solomon tried every pleasure under the sun to seek satisfaction and finally determined, *“Behold that which I have seen: it is good and comely for one to eat and to drink, and to enjoy the good of all his labour that he taketh under the sun all the days of his life, which God giveth him: for it is his portion. Every man also to whom God hath given riches and wealth, and hath given him power to eat thereof, and to take his portion, and to rejoice in his labour; this is the gift of God. For he shall not much remember the days of his life; because God answereth him in the joy of his heart” (Ecclesiastes 5:18-20, KJV).*

“I denied myself nothing my eyes desired; I refused my heart no pleasure. My heart took delight in all my labor, and this was the reward for all my toil” (Ecclesiastes 2:10, NIV).

Work or labor is a gift from God. If you have the health and ability to work, you are missing out if you don’t do it.

George Washington Carver grew up a slave and lived through the abolition of slavery. During this period, labor was looked at as shameful by whites and blacks because it reminded them of the days of slavery. Only slaves labored. George Washington Carver opened schools to teach black communities labor skills that would make them employable, but the first obstacle was to change their mindset on the idea of physical labor. He taught that labor was not shameful but honorable.

He was a scholar and teacher who was an advisor of numerous presidents, and the thing he took the most pride in was the fact that his son became an excellent brick maker.

Prayer

“And he spake a parable unto them to this end, that men ought always to pray, and not to faint; saying, There was in a city a judge, which feared not God, neither regarded man: and there was a widow in that city; and she came unto him, saying, Avenge me of mine adversary. And he would not for a while: but afterward he said within himself, Though I fear not God, nor regard man; yet because this widow troubleth me, I will avenge her, lest by her continual coming she weary me. And the Lord said, Hear what the unjust judge saith. And shall not God avenge his own elect, which cry day and night unto him, though he bear long with them? I tell you that he will avenge them speedily. Nevertheless when the Son of man cometh, shall he find faith on the earth” (Luke 18:1-8, KJV)?

In my life, I have experienced different types of prayer. I have prayed **urgently** when I or a loved one was in immediate danger of health or injury. I have prayed under the **anointing** when I felt that I was speaking to God face to face. And I have prayed for the safety of my family and coworkers on a daily basis as a routine when I felt like it and when I didn’t. I have found that God is faithful in every instance.

My daily prayer, after years and years would seem dry to any of you, and I am sure seems dry to Donna sometimes, but God is faithful in the dry season and in the rainy season, wet with his anointing. I see the effects of this daily prayer over time and can only compare it to a steady gentle breeze against the sail of a ship, not lurching, but continually moving the vessel in the desired direction. Don’t drop your sails; don’t give up on prayer.

As a good Father, God does not leave his children unprepared. He gives us everything we need for a full and victorious life.

“The thief cometh not, but for to steal, and to kill, and to destroy: I am come that they might have life, and that they might have it more abundantly” (John 10:10, KJV).

Amen. ✝

Dickson Julius Olan'g - Our Good Brother

Though we trust in the Lord's perfect timing, saying goodbye to our dear brother weighs heavily on our hearts. He was cherished by all who had the privilege of knowing him and sharing in his company. Truly one of a kind, he had a way of captivating everyone around him with his warm smile and delightful sense of humor. His life was a reflection of Christ's love. *"Let your light shine before others, that they may see your good deeds and glorify your Father in heaven"* (Matthew 5:16).



Dickson Julius Olan'g (69) served faithfully as a Travelling Elder in Africa, ministering across East Africa (Kenya, Tanzania, and Uganda), Central Africa (DR Congo), and West Africa (Ghana), all while firmly rooted in his beloved Tanzania.

Bro. Dickson made his home in Bunda, a picturesque town just a few miles from the Serengeti National Park and the shores of Lake Victoria. Under his devoted guidance,

churches across Africa flourished. Though he suffered a serious injury many years ago that made walking difficult, he never hesitated to serve faithfully, travelling far and wide to visit local churches in each country.

He often joked that he was "local wherever he went"—a Kenyan in Kenya, a Ugandan in Uganda. And, truth be told, he certainly made himself right at home, feeling like a member of each family he met along the way.

We know the days ahead will be profoundly challenging, not only for his dear family, whom he loved so much, but also for the local churches across Africa, which he served with unwavering dedication. We humbly ask God to bless and look after his wife, Margareth, his children, and his grandchildren.

Bro. Dickson loved the Lord, and the Lord loved him. He has now received his heavenly reward. We look forward to meeting him again in those Elysian fields, but until that day, he will be greatly missed.

"Lakini Bwana alisimama pamoja nami na kunitia nguvu, ili kupitia kazi yangu, ujumbe wake utangazwe kikamilifu na kusikika na Mataifa yote; nami nikaokolewa katika kinywa cha simba. Bwana ataniokoa kutoka kwa kila neno baya na kunihifadhi hadi nifike katika ufalme wake wa mbinguni. Utukufu una Yeye milele na milele. Amina" (2 Timotheo 4:17-18).

"But the Lord stood with me and strengthened me, so that through my work, His message might be fully proclaimed, and all the nations might hear it; and I was rescued from the lion's mouth. The Lord will rescue me from every evil deed and bring me safely into His heavenly kingdom. To Him be the glory forever and ever. Amen" (2 Timothy 4:17-18).

Tunakupenda ndugu mpendwa. Bwana asifiwe.

~ The Brethren ✝

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Headquarters:
802 Airport Road
North Battleford, SK S9A 2Z3 Canada

Mailing Address:
P.O. Box 934
North Battleford, SK S9A 2Z3 Canada

Telephone:
(306) 445-2733

Email:
info@globalmissionsinc.org

Online:
www.globalmissionsinc.org

Traveling Ministry Contact List:
www.globalmissionsinc.org/about

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